

Political Science 51: The Scientific Study of Politics

TR, 9:00–10:20 AM

Scrub Oak Auditorium 160

<https://canvas.ucdavis.edu/courses/1077608>

Section A01: T, 4:10–5 PM (50850)

Section A02: T, 5:10–6 PM (50851)

Section A03: W, 9–9:50 AM (50852)

Section A04: W, 10–10:50 AM (50853)

Section A05: R, 3:10–4 PM (50854)

Section A06: R, 4:10–5 PM (50855)

Section A07: F, 10–10:50 AM (54908)

Section A08: F, 11–11:50 AM (54910)

Instructor

Christopher Hare

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Office Location: Kerr 574

Office Hours: F 9–11 AM

Teaching assistants

Alexa Federice

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Kerr 675

Office Hours: W 11 AM–1 PM

Sophie Green

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Kerr 685

Office Hours: W 1–3 PM

Alperen Sen

(A01/A02)

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Kerr 660

Office Hours: T 1:30–3:30 PM

Max Welch

(A07/A08)

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Kerr 662

Office Hours: W 10 AM–12 PM

Course description

This course provides an introduction to the *science* of political science. The first part of the course focuses on key concepts in the scientific study of politics: theory building, research design, and the measurement of political variables. The second component of the course provides training on methods for the empirical analysis of data, including an introduction to the R programming environment.

Required texts

1. Paul M. Kellstedt and Guy D. Whitten. *The Fundamentals of Political Science Research*, 3rd ed. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2018. ISBN: 978-1-108-69880-1
2. **Available online through UCD Libraries.** Jim Albert and Maria Rizzo. *R by Example*, 2nd ed. New York: Springer, 2024. ISBN: 978-3-031-76073-0

Journal articles/handouts will be made available on the class Canvas page.

Grade components

Assignments	30%
Midterm Exam (May 14, 9:00 - 10:20 AM)	35%
Final Exam (June 10, 10:30 AM - 12:30 PM)	35%

Grading system

≥ 97	A+	87 - 89	B+	77 - 79	C+	67 - 69	D+	< 60	F
93 - 96	A	83 - 86	B	73 - 76	C	63 - 66	D		
90 - 92	A-	80 - 82	B-	70 - 72	C-	60 - 62	D-		

Class attendance

I consider college students fully capable of making appropriate decisions with respect to class attendance and equally capable of living with the consequences of those decisions.

Assignments and exams

There will be four homework assignments assigned throughout the course. I will drop the lowest grade, meaning that the remaining assignments each count 10% towards your final grade. No extensions will be given for any assignment without prior approval, or without a written medical excuse or note from the Dean's office. All late papers will be graded down one portion of a grade (e.g., from a "B+" to a "B") for every day late, including Saturday and Sunday.

Assignments must be submitted through Canvas.

Inquiries about assignments and exams—especially those concerning logistics about completing/taking these—should generally be made to your assigned section head (i.e., the teaching assistant managing your section). However, I am more than happy to answer substantive questions about the course material or discuss political science, graduate school, career opportunities, etc. either in office hours or by appointment.

Makeup exams

Makeup exams will not be administered without prior approval, or without a written medical excuse or note from the Dean's office. You should make arrangements with your assigned section teaching assistant as soon as possible if you know that you will be absent for one of the exams.

Extra credit

At random points throughout the course, I will provide **in-class** extra credit opportunities. These must be completed in person, no makeups. Depending on assignment and exam grades, I may

curve grades upward (I will never curve downwards). However, based on past experiences, this is unlikely. I will also round final grades a point (e.g., an 89.5 to a 90).

Academic honesty

I strictly adhere to the UC Davis Code of Academic Conduct (<http://sja.ucdavis.edu/cac.html>). I will report any suspected academic misconduct to Student Judicial Affairs.

Disabilities

Students with special needs that require accommodation should notify the Student Disability Center (54 Cowell Building; 530.752.3184; <https://sdc.ucdavis.edu>) as soon as possible so that arrangements detailed in the Letter of Accommodation can be made.

Tentative schedule

This schedule is subject to change:

Week	Topic	Readings
Week 1 March 31 - April 2	Introduction	
Week 2 April 7 - April 9	Theory-Building: Rational Choice and Game Theory	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapter 1. • James McManus, “Game Theory: Poker, Bluffing, and the Royal Flush of Cold Warfare,” http://www.nytimes.com/2005/10/01/sports/othersports/bluffing-and-the-royal-flush-of-cold-warfare.html
Week 3 April 14 - April 16	Theory-Building: Issues with Rational Chocie Theory and the Spatial Voting Model	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapter 2. • Jonah Lehrer, “The Allais Paradox,” https://www.wired.com/2010/10/the-allais-paradox/
Week 4 April 21 NO CLASS: April 23 (Midwest Political Science Association)	CONTINUED... Theory-Building: Issues with Rational Chocie Theory and the Spatial Voting Model	

Week 5 April 28 - April 30 Assignment #1 Due: April 28	Causation, Research Design, and Measurement	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapters 3-5. • Ronald E. Milliman, “Using Background Music to Affect the Behavior of Supermarket Shoppers,” <i>Journal of Marketing</i> 46: 86-91. • Seva Gunitsky, “How Do You Measure ‘Democracy’?,” https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/monkey-cage/wp/2015/06/23/how-do-you-measure-democracy
Week 6 May 5 - May 7	Introduction to R	• <i>R by Example</i>, Chapters 1, 5. • CRAN: https://cran.r-project.org/ • The R Graph Gallery, https://www.r-graph-gallery.com/
Week 7 May 12 - May 14 Midterm Exam: May 14 Assignment #2 Due: May 15	Carch-up/Review and Midterm Exam	
Week 8 May 19 - May 21	Probability and Statistical Inference	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapters 6-7. • Nate Silver, ‘Polling Is Not the Problem,’ https://www.nytimes.com/2024/11/19/opinion/polling-election-trump-harris.html?unlocked_article_code=1.nE4.jkse.1h6NJ_Tf3ZJF&smid=url-share
Week 9 May 26 - May 28 Assignment #3 Due: May 29	Correlation and Bivariate Regression	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapters 8-9. • <i>R by Example</i>, Chapters 2, 7. • <i>Harvard Business Review</i>, “Beware Spurious Correlations,” https://hbr.org/2015/06/beware-spurious-correlations

Week 10 June 2 - June 4 Assignment #4 Due: June 5	Multiple Regression	• <i>Fundamentals of Political Science Research</i>, Chapters 10-11. • <i>R by Example</i>, Chapter 8. • Hope Martinez, “The Effect of Incarceration on Political Beliefs for Vulnerable Populations,” <i>Social Science Quarterly</i> in press.
Exam Week Final Exam: Wednesday, June 10, 10:30 AM–12:30 PM		